held, uncle?" asked Maran.

"Grama Sabha meetings? In movies, I have seen elders sitting under trees and discussing important matters and take decisions," said Johnson.

"No, no, both are different. A Grama Sabha is formed in every Village Panchayat. It is the only permanent unit in the Panchayat Raj System. Grama Sabha meetings are held even in smaller villages. The Grama Sabha is the grass root level democratic institution in a Village Panchayat".



Those who have attained the age of 18 years and whose names are found in the electoral roll of the same Panchayat can take part in a Grama Sabha meeting. The Grama Sabha meetings are conducted four times a year. Officers like the District Collector, the Block Development Officer, Panchyat President, Vice President, and Ward Members etc., also participate in this meeting. The people can freely express their needs and grievances".

When are these meetings convened?

January 26, May 1, August 15 and October 2.

Apart from these days, the meetings can be convened as per need or during emergency. These are called Special Grama Sabha meetings.

Activity

The teacher guides the student to visit the Grama Sabha meeting.

"Mahatma Gandhi advocated Panchayat Raj as the foundation of India's political system, as a form of government, where each village would be responsible for its own affairs. The Panchayat Raj Act was enacted on April 24, 1992".

DO YOU KNOW?

April 24 is National Panchayat Raj Day.

Special features of Panchayat Raj

- Grama Sabha
- Three tier local body governance
- Reservations
- Panchayat Elections
- Tenure
- Finance Commission
- Account and Audit, etc

"Thank you very much, uncle. We really learnt a lot about local bodies", said the children gratefully.

"I'm very happy that I could share so much with you today. That's enough of reading newspapers. Go out and play now", said Namburajan.

The children ran out to play joyously.

Activity

The Central Government gives awards to the best performing Village Panchayats. Find out if your village has received such awards.

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